



TOP STORY

One of the strictest homeless camp bans in the U.S. just passed in the Bay Area

LOCAL

A virtual Yosemite experience just arrived near [unclear] Is it worth [unclear]

By **Grant M**
Updated [unclear]



SFGATE

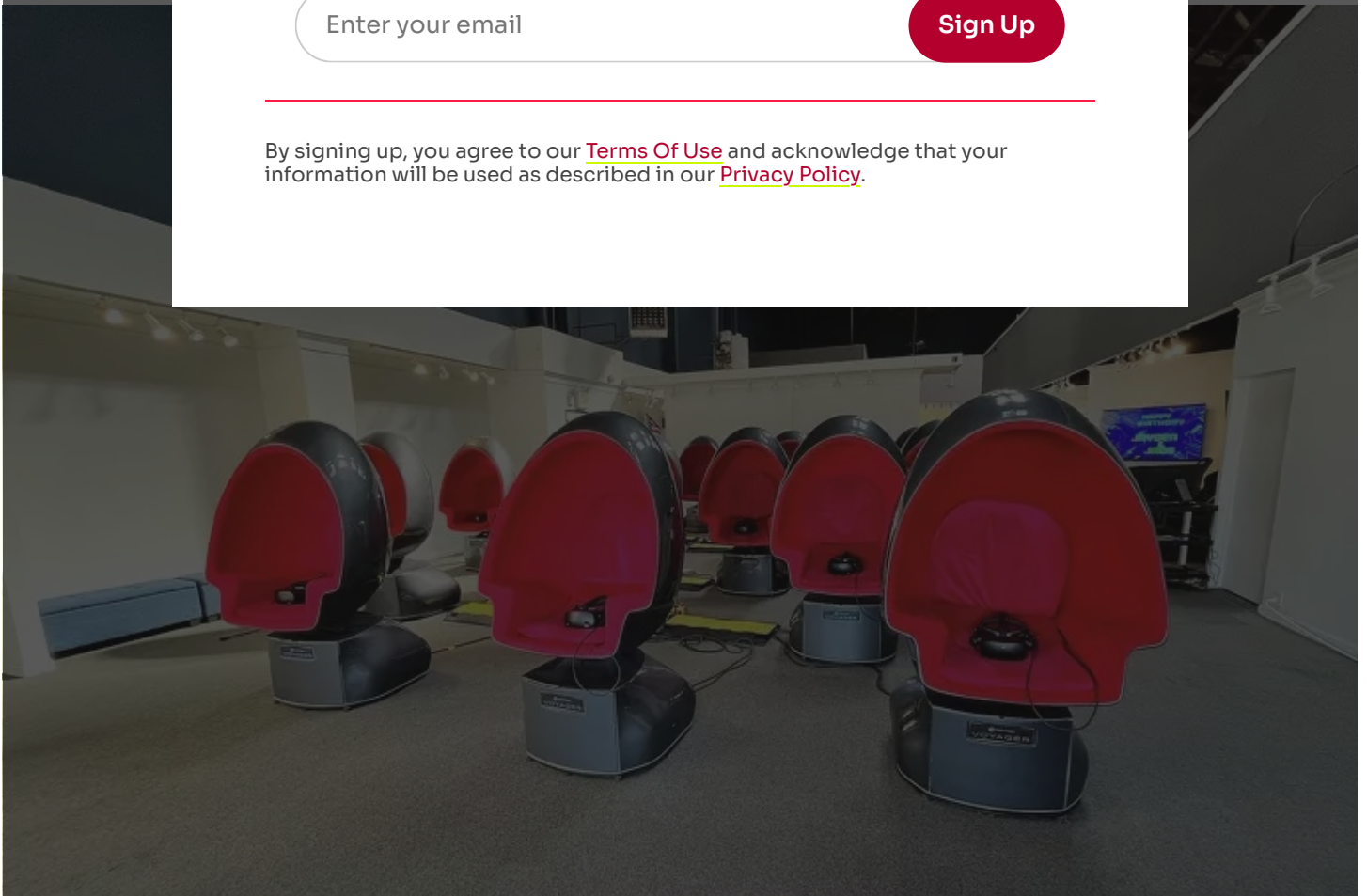
THE DAILY

Get the Bay Area's best free local newsletter.

Email

Sign Up

By signing up, you agree to our [Terms Of Use](#) and acknowledge that your information will be used as described in our [Privacy Policy](#).



A look inside GamedayVR, a shop near Ghirardelli Square that hosts "Yosemite Experience," a virtual tour of Yosemite.

Grant Marek/SFGATE

Yosemite is unequivocally one of the most beautiful places on planet Earth.

Watch More

SFG

A map showing the influenza flu activity in the U.S. as of Feb 01, 2025

2024-25 Influenza Season Week 8 ending Feb 01, 2025

flu activity,

Centers For Disease Control And Prevention

Keep Watching

2

And virtual reality Yosemite is unequivocally not.

ADVERTISEMENT

Article continues below this ad

That's what I learned on a reticent recent trip to the tourist magnet that is Ghirardelli Square to try "Yosemite Experience," a virtual reality gimmick that bills itself as "San Francisco's best cinematic experience!" (exclamation point included).

Curiously, no one wants to see that superlative offering when I arrive at GamedayVR on a Friday afternoon. The cavernous warehouse, which is actually an auxiliary space a few doors down from GamedayVR's Ghirardelli Square location, is completely deserted save for the lone employee, whose head is buried in his smartphone. Inside the space are more than a dozen egg-shaped chairs with plush red lining, an unexplained NASA space suit and two billboards for "Yosemite Experience," one with the unattributed "best cinematic experience!" quote and another that calls it "the future of cinema."



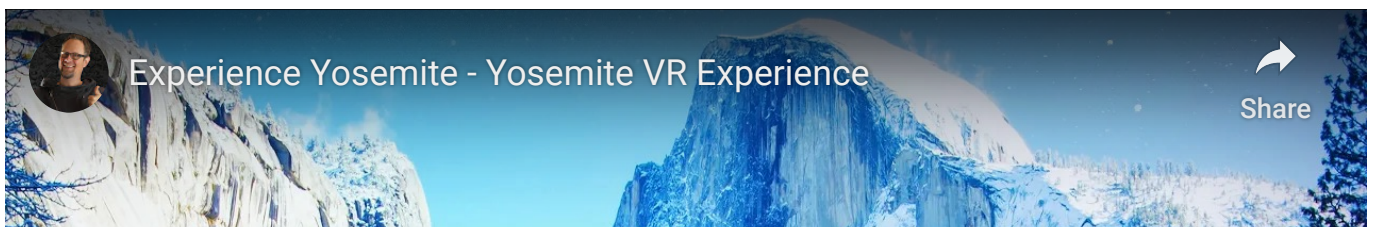




Screenshots of the "Yosemite Experience" virtual reality experience, plus two photos inside GamedayVR, which hosts the CityLights VR production. (Screenshots courtesy of CityLights, photos via Grant Marek/SFGATE)

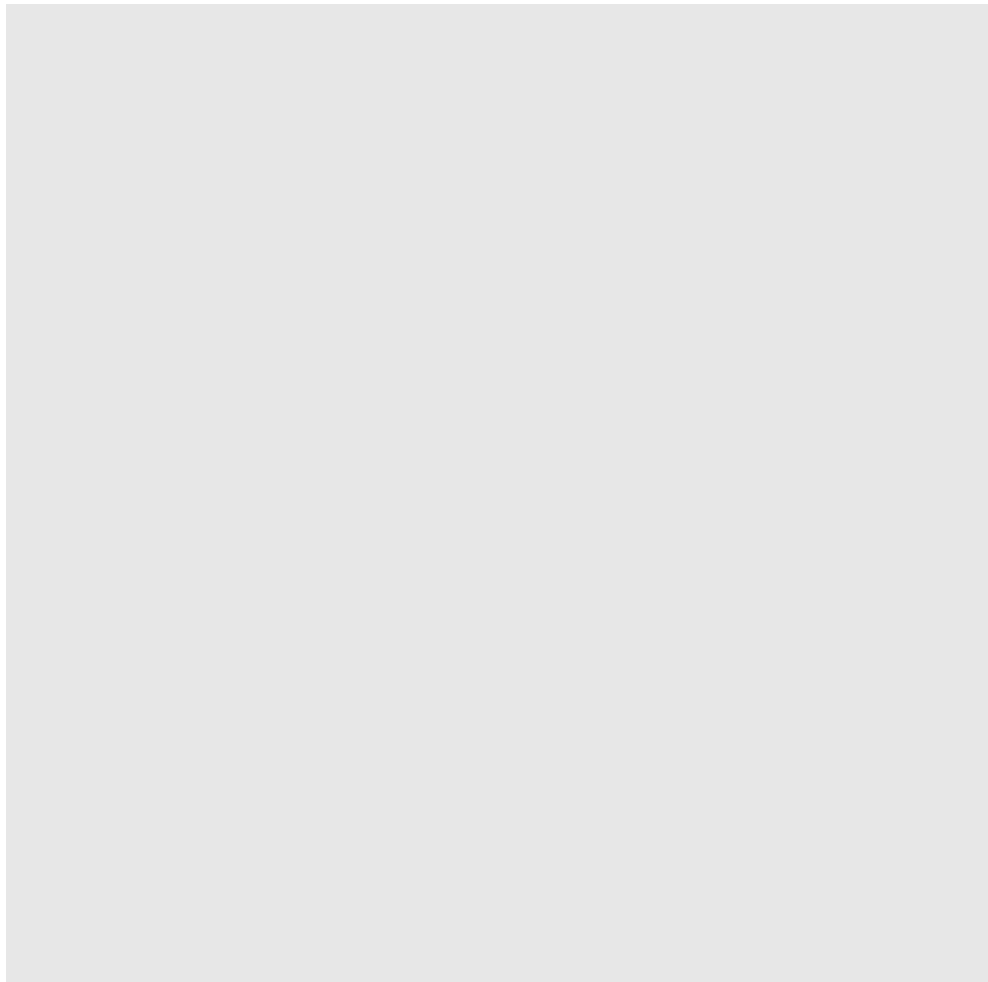
I check into my "future of cinema" experience and am escorted to my virtual reality chair. The college kid who's in charge tells me not to put my backpack against the egg because it will be moving. (Spoiler: It ends up moving very, very, very little, dear reader.)

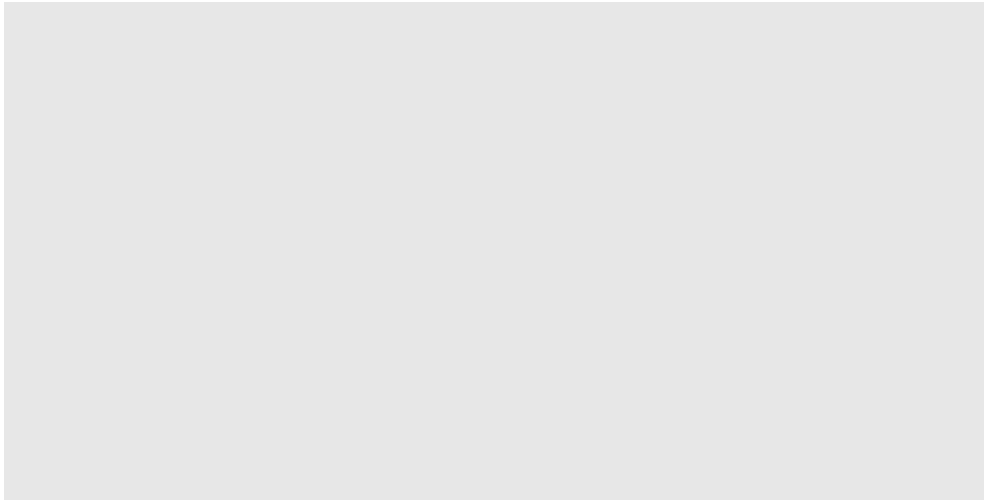
I sink into the comfortable egg chair and put on my virtual reality headset. For the next 15 minutes, I'm subjected to one of the saddest cinematic experiences of my life.





It's hard to even explain how bad the graphics for "Yosemite Experience" are. They look somewhere between 1992's *Wolfenstein 3D* and 1993's *Myst* — two early-days computer games that were fun despite their rudimentary, 30-year-old 3D graphics. You'll enjoy those while your egg ever so slightly tilts back and forward from time to time, giving you a slow-motion version of one of those plastic horses outside the grocery store you pay a quarter to ride.





A look inside GamedayVR, a shop near Ghirardelli Square that hosts "Yosemite Experience," a virtual tour of Yosemite.

Grant Marek/SFGATE

I initially thought this would be something like one of Oculus' "Star Wars" games, where you can interact with and move around an incredibly cool environment freely, but it's nothing like that in any way. Instead, you're just watching a sad Yosemite movie where you can turn slightly left and right to see a bit more of the screen.

ADVERTISEMENT

Article continues below this ad

Not only is the movie sad, though; it's also *extremely* confusing. It jumps around from John Muir touring Yosemite with Theodore Roosevelt in 1903 (you look in on a campfire meeting between them where they don't move), to Native Americans' history with the land (you end up in a dark cave for a good three minutes, and the

screen repeatedly displays different baskets), to free solo climber Alex Honnold scaling Yosemite's 3,200-foot El Capitan without a rope in 2017, to Ansel Adams taking photos there in 1958. There's no chronology to any of it, and probably the most dramatic moment of the entire thing is when Adams uses a red filter for an El Capitan photo instead of *a yellow one*. There's also a really special moment where the movie shows a popular slacklining spot, and the woman on the slackline somehow actually looks worse than Meta's leg-less VR people.

At several points during the 15 minutes, I can also hear people slamming car doors in real life on Beach St — because of course I can.

The only silver lining of the entire thing is that the filmmakers somehow convinced Bryan Cranston to do the voiceover.

"Yosemite Experience" is only \$10 cheaper than the Yosemite National Park entrance fee for a single car (\$35) if you go alone, and hilariously, there's a totally unaffiliated free site called virtualyosemite.org that is somehow worlds better than this abomination. If you're a tourist visiting San Francisco wondering if this experience is worth spending \$25 on for every member of your family, no, it is not.

ADVERTISEMENT

Article continues below this ad

Might I instead suggest doing what I did after I finished subjecting myself to this: I

walked over to Buena Vista Cafe, which is on the same block, and enjoyed a nonvirtual Irish coffee, unequivocally one of the very best San Francisco experiences.

Editor's note: This story was updated at 9:45 a.m., Dec. 2, to correct location details and the name of the attraction.

Nov 28, 2022 | Updated Dec 2, 2022 10:30 a.m.



Grant Marek

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF



Grant Marek is SFGATE's editor-in-chief. He's held various editorial roles for Thrillist, Yahoo Sports, the San Francisco Examiner, the Desert Sun, the Santa Clarita Valley Signal and Sports Illustrated. He's a graduate of UC Berkeley and has lived in the Bay Area since 2001. You can email him at grant.marek@sfgate.com.

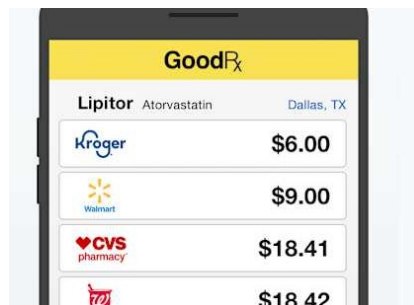
Around The Web

Powered by **REVCONTENT**



Stop Information Overload

By **Ethereal Search Engine**



Stop Paying Too Much for Your Prescriptions – Compare Prices, Find Free Coupons,

By

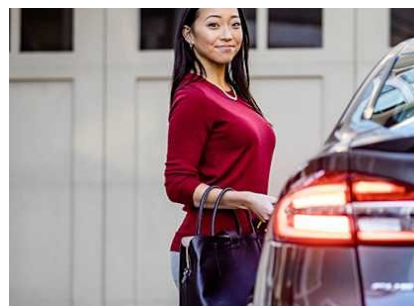


The New Normal of Selling a Home Today

By



The Best Places to Buy College Apparel Make



How Long Should I Keep My Car?



Got Plant Milk? Add These 16 Plant Milks to

Showing College Pride Too Easy

By



Did Your Mom Ever Make the Paper? Search Newspapers.com

By

By



Should You Buy an Electric Car?

By

Your Mug for Health, Flavor, and Fro

By



Get Dog Food Designed for Your Dog's Health & Happiness

By

Let's Play

Typeshift

Really Bad Chess

Flipart

Cross|word

SFGATE



Top ^

About

Contact

Services

Quick Links